Pakistan is a key partner in the WOT and plays a major role in our long-term efforts to build a stable Afghanistan. Without CSF reimbursements Pakistan could not afford to deploy and maintain 100,000 military and paramilitary forces in the Federally Administered Tribal Areas (FATA). Since 2001, the Pakistan Army has conducted 91 major and countless small operations in support of the WOT, and it has captured or killed more Al Qaeda and Taliban than any other coalition partner. Following Pakistan's decision in July 2007 to remove by force a group of religious extremists that had taken over the Red Mosque in Islamabad, the number of retaliatory suicide bombings and ambushes of Pakistani military and police personnel increased dramatically. Since September 11, 2001, has taken efforts to combat extremists in the FATA, resulting in the death or capture of a number of Taliban leaders in the past year. In the past five years, Pakistani soldiers have sustained more than 1,400 combat deaths—700 just since July 2007—and more than 2,400 wounded in action.

THE FEDERALLY ADMINISTERED TRIBAL AREAS (FA TA)

On a final note, the security of the border between Afghanistan and Pakistan has been the subject of increasing interest and concern to the Administration, Congress, and the International Community, including the governments of Afghanistan and Pakistan. The FATA border region with Afghanistan is now and has historically been a largely ungoverned space. This area—approximately the size of Maryland—was identified in the July 2007 National Intelligence Estimate (NIE) on the Terrorist Threat to the U.S. Homeland and the Country Reports on Terrorism 2007 as a safe haven where Taliban and Al Qaeda forces recruit, train and equip fighters and infiltrate them into Afghanistan. The FATA has always had a special constitutional status in Pakistan. Normal federal or provincial laws do not apply, and the area is only loosely governed under the provisions of the century-old Frontier Crimes Regulations. Operating there is challenging even for the non-Pashtun Pakistanis who are generally considered to be outsiders and interlopers by the fiercely independent Pashtun tribesman. The tribes of the FATA have a long history of military resistance and success in preventing foreign armies from entering and conquering their tribal areas.

It is only by working with Pakistani military and security elements, such as the Frontier Corps and the Special Services Group (SSG), that security is possible in the FATA and NWFP. Neither the Government of Pakistan (GoP) nor a large majority of Pakistan's population support a U.S. troop presence in the country. The U.S. cannot afford to lose the hearts and minds of the Pakistani people. The United States is committed to stopping Al Qaeda, the Taliban, and other terrorist groups that threaten the stability and development of the FATA and the NWFP as well as Pakistanis' freedom and the open, democratic, and economically prosperous society that Pakistan is working to achieve. Consequently, the U.S. is assisting Pakistan with equipping and training of the Frontier Corps and supporting the government's frontier development strategy.

The U.S. is deeply concerned about reports of ceasefire negotiations and other agreements in South Waziristan and other locations in the FATA and North West Frontier Province (NWFP). Previous attempts by the GoP to negotiate ceasefires and other agreements with the tribes in the FATA and NWFP were deeply flawed. After similar agreements were signed in 2005 and 2006, cross-border operations by extremist groups against U.S. and

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